Chapter 23 – The Space Program

"India is not, as people keep calling it, an underdeveloped country, but rather, in the context of its history and cultural heritage, a highly developed one in an advanced state of decay."

(Shashi Tharoor)

Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru established the India National Committee for Space Research in 1962 to bring his country into the space age alongside the Soviet Union and the United States. Though India did not have the financial resources necessary to race its colleagues in putting humans on the moon, it did have an inspirational background of scientific and mathematical minds to rival any in the world. Under the direction of Dr. Vikran Sarabhai, the department and its successor, the Indian Space Research Organization, launched a successful project to manufacture and launch a satellite into orbit. That satellite, called Aryabhata in honor of the 6th-century mathematician, did indeed reach orbit in 1975, thanks to a ride on a Soviet Union rocket. Sarabhai and his associates also built the Thumba Equatorial Rocket Launching Station near the southernmost tip of mainland India, very near to Earth's natural magnetic equator to best facilitate atmospheric research.

ISRO, the Indian Space Research Organization, replaced Nehru's original agency in 1969. Tasked with developing space-age technology for use within India, as well as cooperating in space exploration, ISRO successfully built an astonishing number of crafts and machinery that aided all space age nations in their pursuit of knowledge. In the first decades of ISRO, the organization mostly focused on building and launching rockets that could bring payloads into orbit around the earth and the moon.

In the 1980s, ISRO made nine successful satellite launches that would be used as broadcasting and communication links. In 1984, the first Indian was sent into space: Rakesh Sharma. Sharma was an Indian Air Force pilot chosen by the Soviet Interkosmos program to fly in the Soyuz T-11 spacecraft to link with the Salyut 7 space station. The mission was a success, and with Rakesh Sharma aboard the Soviet space station as a Research Cosmonaut, his mission was to observe Earth from space. In addition to specific observation schemes, Sharma conducted various